

PEPS-Y W2: Baltic Crisis module

Hybrid vignette design for measuring European solidarity under the threat of Russian military aggression

Overview

The block is designed to fit into approximately 5–6 minutes of a 20-minute survey. It measures support for costly collective action if Russia launches a military attack against another European country, with particular attention to the case of a Baltic EU/NATO country. The block distinguishes symbolic support from willingness to accept personal, material, and human costs.

The broader PEPS-Y project studies political solidarity, identity, redistribution, and willingness to accept costs for others. This module keeps that focus: it uses a hypothetical security crisis to examine the high-stakes implications of costly European solidarity under external military threat.

Theoretical Motivation

The module treats solidarity as willingness to support another political community even when support is personally or nationally costly. Work on international redistribution and European crisis solidarity shows why this is theoretically interesting: support for other countries is not reducible to narrow material self-interest, and may instead reflect altruism, cosmopolitan orientations, European identity, and other-regarding concerns (Bechtel et al. 2014; Verhaegen 2018).

At the same time, solidarity has boundaries. Citizens distinguish between co-nationals, other Europeans, and more distant outsiders, while support for aid also depends on recipient characteristics and relational proximity (Kuhn and Kamm 2019; Heermann et al. 2023). A Baltic crisis is a productive example because it asks whether solidarity extends beyond symbolic support to costly action for politically proximate Europeans under direct external threat.

The module also distinguishes cost levels. Support may remain high for statements of solidarity, humanitarian assistance, or sanctions, but decline when the scenario implies higher prices, taxes, civil support work or possible casualties. This cost gradient is central to the Ukraine/Russia context, where public support for solidarity is shaped by economic costs, energy prices and attitudes toward escalation or appeasement (Oana et al. 2025; Moise and Wang 2025).

Finally, the design must account for NATO without making NATO the central object of the module. All countries in the PEPS-Y sample are NATO members, and likely Baltic target countries are also NATO members. A Baltic crisis would therefore plausibly be interpreted by respondents not only as a question of European solidarity but also as a question of alliance obligation. This matters because alliance commitments can independently increase support for defending an attacked country, including through reputational and moral-obligation mechanisms (Tomz and Weeks 2021; Tomz et al. 2023).

Design implication

The preferred baseline keeps NATO in the background with minimal but realistic wording. This preserves the PEPS-Y focus on European solidarity while acknowledging that a Baltic military crisis would almost inevitably be understood through NATO obligations.

Existing Identity block and order randomization

The existing identity items should remain unchanged for cross-wave comparability:

- *Please indicate how close you feel to [country].*
- *Please indicate how close you feel to Europe.*
- *Please indicate how close you feel to your municipality.*
- *Please indicate how close you feel to the world.*

The order of the identity block and the Baltic Crisis module should be randomized:

Condition	Order	Interpretation
1	Identity block before Baltic Crisis module	Identity is measured before the crisis scenario and can be used as a moderator, but the measurement itself may also increase identity salience.
2	Identity block after Baltic Crisis module	Identity is measured after the crisis scenario and should not be used as a clean pre-treatment moderator. It can instead be interpreted as post-scenario identity expression.

The order randomization is designed to handle a basic measurement problem. Placing the identity block before the crisis module allows us to examine whether closeness to country, Europe, municipality, or the world predicts support for costly collective action. However, this measure is not completely neutral, because asking identity questions may itself make identity more salient. Placing the identity block after the crisis module avoids this identity prime before the vignette, but then identity is post-scenario and cannot be interpreted as a clean pre-treatment moderator. Comparing the two orders allows us to test whether making identity salient before the crisis scenario changes support for costly solidarity.

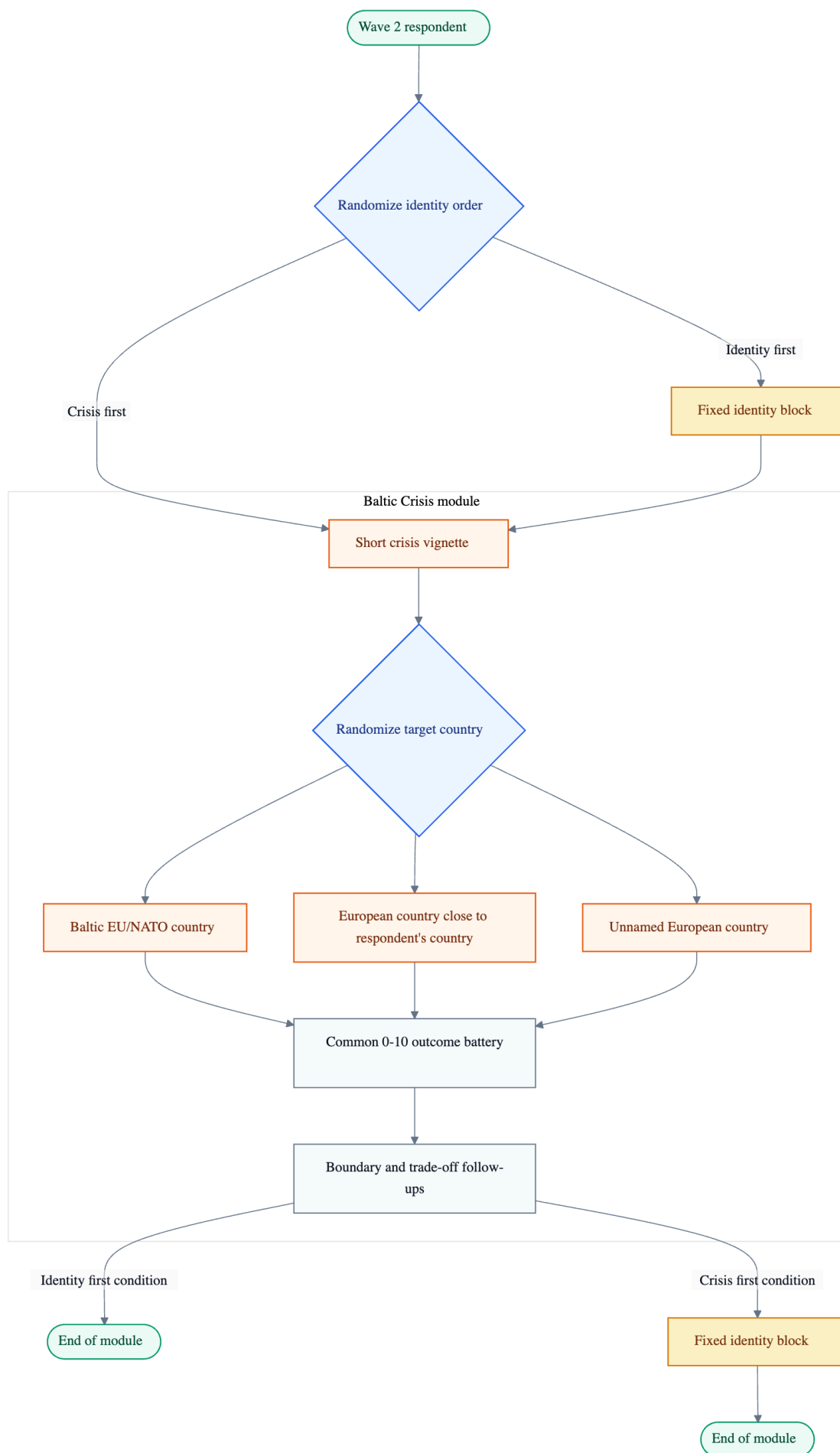


Figure 1: Recommended randomization flow: identity order plus three target-country arms.

Overall module architecture and between-subject design

The recommended architecture is a hybrid design:

- a short **between-subject** vignette with very few levels;
- a common outcome battery measuring different levels of sacrifice;
- one or two **within-subject** follow-up items to map solidarity boundaries without creating too many between-subject cells.

With approximately 600-800 respondents per country, and with identity order also randomized, too many between-subject cells become thin for country-specific estimates. This lean hybrid design preserves experimental clarity while keeping statistical power.

Sample-size context

Land/region	Survey language	Minimum complete interviews in Wave 2
Germany-West	German	700
Germany-East	German	300
France without overseas territories	French	800
Italy	Italian	800
Poland	Polish	800
Sweden	Swedish	800
Spain	Spanish (Castilian)	800
Croatia	Croatian	800

With three target arms and two identity-order conditions, the recommended design creates six experimental cells before any country-specific subgrouping. Approximate cell sizes are therefore about 117 in Germany-West, 50 in Germany-East, and 133 in the 800-respondent countries. Country-specific estimates are possible but should be interpreted cautiously especially for interactions.

Two Principal Design Variants

The study team should distinguish two ways of making the crisis realistic. These variants are useful as design alternatives, even if the baseline ultimately chooses one.

Variant	Benefit	Cost
A. European solidarity framing with NATO in the background	Better aligned with the PEPS-Y focus on European solidarity and identity. Less likely to become merely a NATO-attitude module. Allows closeness to Europe to be a central theoretical predictor.	May feel less institutionally realistic because actual Baltic defense is strongly tied to NATO. Respondents may still infer NATO obligations, so the absence of explicit NATO language does not remove NATO from the scenario.
B. Formal NATO obligation framing	Institutionally realistic. Gives respondents a clear reason why [country] is involved. Allows items about Article 5, alliance obligations, military deployment, and burden-sharing to be interpreted clearly.	The construct becomes support for NATO burden-sharing or alliance obligation rather than pure European solidarity. Responses may be driven by NATO attitudes, anti-Americanism, military hawkishness, pacifism, or pro-/anti-Russian attitudes.

Variant A: European solidarity framing with NATO in the background

This variant emphasizes Russia attacking a European country and European governments discussing a joint response. NATO is mentioned only where necessary, for example when the attacked country is described as a Baltic EU/NATO member. Outcome items mostly use language such as “joint European response,” “support for the attacked country,” and “costs for citizens in [country].”

Example vignette wording:

Please imagine the following situation. Russia launches a military attack against a Baltic EU/NATO country. European governments, including the government of [country], discuss a joint response to defend the attacked country and support its population.

Variant B: Formal NATO obligation framing

This variant explicitly states that Russia attacks a NATO ally and that NATO governments discuss invoking Article 5 or fulfilling collective-defense commitments.

Example vignette wording:

Please imagine the following situation. Russia launches a military attack against a Baltic NATO ally. NATO governments, including the government of [country], discuss invoking Article 5 and fulfilling their collective-defense commitments.

Recommended between-subject vignette structure

The recommended baseline is target-country framing with NATO language held minimal and realistic. The main arms are:

Arm	Target wording	Purpose
A	Russia attacks a Baltic EU/NATO country.	Primary case. Captures solidarity with a plausible Baltic target while acknowledging EU/NATO membership.
B	Russia attacks a European country close to [country].	Tests whether geographical proximity or regional exposure raises support.
C	Russia attacks an unnamed European country.	Provides a more generic European-solidarity benchmark.

“Your own country” should not be a main vignette arm in the baseline because it changes the construct from solidarity with others to national self-defense. I would prefer to include it into a follow-up comparison block (see below).

Common outcome battery of questions after the vignette

All items should be asked after any vignette arm using the same 0–10 response format. The shared scale makes it possible to compare support across different types of costly solidarity: policy support, personal material sacrifice, and military-risk acceptance.

Suggested scale: 0 = do not support / would not accept at all; 10 = fully support / would fully accept.

A. Collective policy support

- [Country] should support a joint response to defend [attacked_country].
- [Country] should impose strong sanctions on Russia, even if this increases prices for citizens in [country].
- [Country] should send military equipment and weapons to [attacked_country].
- [Country] should accept refugees from [attacked_country].

B. Material personal sacrifice

- I would accept higher energy prices for several months if this helped support the joint response.
- I would be willing to pay an additional monthly tax equivalent to one day of median income in [country] to fund defense and support measures.
- I would be willing to do 6 hours of civil support work once a month, such as logistics, refugee support, or civil defense.

C. Military and human-risk threshold

- [Country] should send troops as part of a joint operation if this is necessary to defend [attacked_country].
- [Country] should send troops even if this creates a serious risk of casualties among soldiers from [country].

Within-subject follow-up items

We will ask one or two follow-up items after the main battery to map the boundaries of solidarity. These items are asked of all respondents regardless of vignette arm, and they are not randomized. They are designed to be compact and non-repetitive, so that they do not create too many between-subject cells when combined with identity order and target-country arms.

Follow-up 1: Boundary of solidarity

Would your support for the joint response be higher, lower, or about the same if the attacked country were...

- your own country;
- a neighboring European country;
- a Baltic EU/NATO country;
- a non-EU European country.

Follow-up 2: Priority trade-off

In this situation, what should [country] prioritize more?

0 = avoiding costs for citizens in [country]
10 = contributing to the defense of [attacked_country]

This item directly measures the central trade-off between national cost avoidance and costly collective defense.

Some participant-facing example cards

Participant-facing example: Germany

Vignette, Baltic target arm. Please imagine the following situation. Russia launches a military attack against a Baltic EU/NATO country. European governments, including the government of Germany, discuss a joint response to defend the attacked country and support its population.

Question screen. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 means “do not support at all” and 10 means “fully support,” how much do you support the following?

- Germany should impose strong sanctions on Russia, even if this increases prices for citizens in Germany.
- I would accept higher energy prices for several months if this helped support the joint response.
- Germany should send troops as part of a joint operation if this is necessary to defend the attacked country.

Participant-facing example: Poland

Vignette, close-country target arm. Please imagine the following situation. Russia launches a military attack against a European country close to Poland. European governments, including the government of Poland, discuss a joint response to defend the attacked country and support its population.

Question screen. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 means “do not support at all” and 10 means “fully support,” how much do you support the following?

- Poland should support a joint response to defend the attacked country.
- Poland should send military equipment and weapons to the attacked country.
- I would be willing to do 6 hours of civil support work once a month, such as logistics, refugee support, or civil defense.

Participant-facing example: Sweden

Vignette, generic European target arm. Please imagine the following situation. Russia launches a military attack against a European country. European governments, including the government of Sweden, discuss a joint response to defend the attacked country and support its population.

Question screen. On a scale from 0 to 10, where 0 means “do not support at all” and 10 means “fully support,” how much do you support the following?

- Sweden should accept refugees from the attacked country.
- I would be willing to pay an additional monthly tax equivalent to one day of median income in Sweden to fund defense and support measures.
- Sweden should send troops even if this creates a serious risk of casualties among soldiers from Sweden.

Analysis Plan

The main outcomes are:

- **Policy support index:** joint response, sanctions, military equipment, and possibly troop deployment depending on scaling.
- **Material sacrifice index:** energy prices, tax, and civil support work.
- **Military-risk support index:** troop deployment and casualty-risk items.
- **Humanitarian support item or sub-index:** refugee acceptance, optionally combined with softer humanitarian support if added later.
- **Trade-off priority score:** 0-10 prioritization between avoiding domestic costs and contributing to defense.

The main predictors and treatment effects are:

- vignette target effects: Baltic EU/NATO country versus close European country versus unnamed European country;
- identity-order effect: identity before crisis versus identity after crisis;

- interaction between identity order and crisis vignette;
- interaction between pre-scenario European, national, local, and world identity and support for costly response, using only the identity-first group. This should be interpreted as moderation under identity-salient conditions, because asking the identity items before the crisis vignette may itself make identity more salient.
- cross-country heterogeneity, interpreted cautiously because country-specific cells may be too small.

Identity measured after the crisis block should not be interpreted as a clean pre-treatment moderator. It is better treated as post-treatment identity expression, or as an outcome-like measure that may itself be affected by exposure to the crisis scenario.

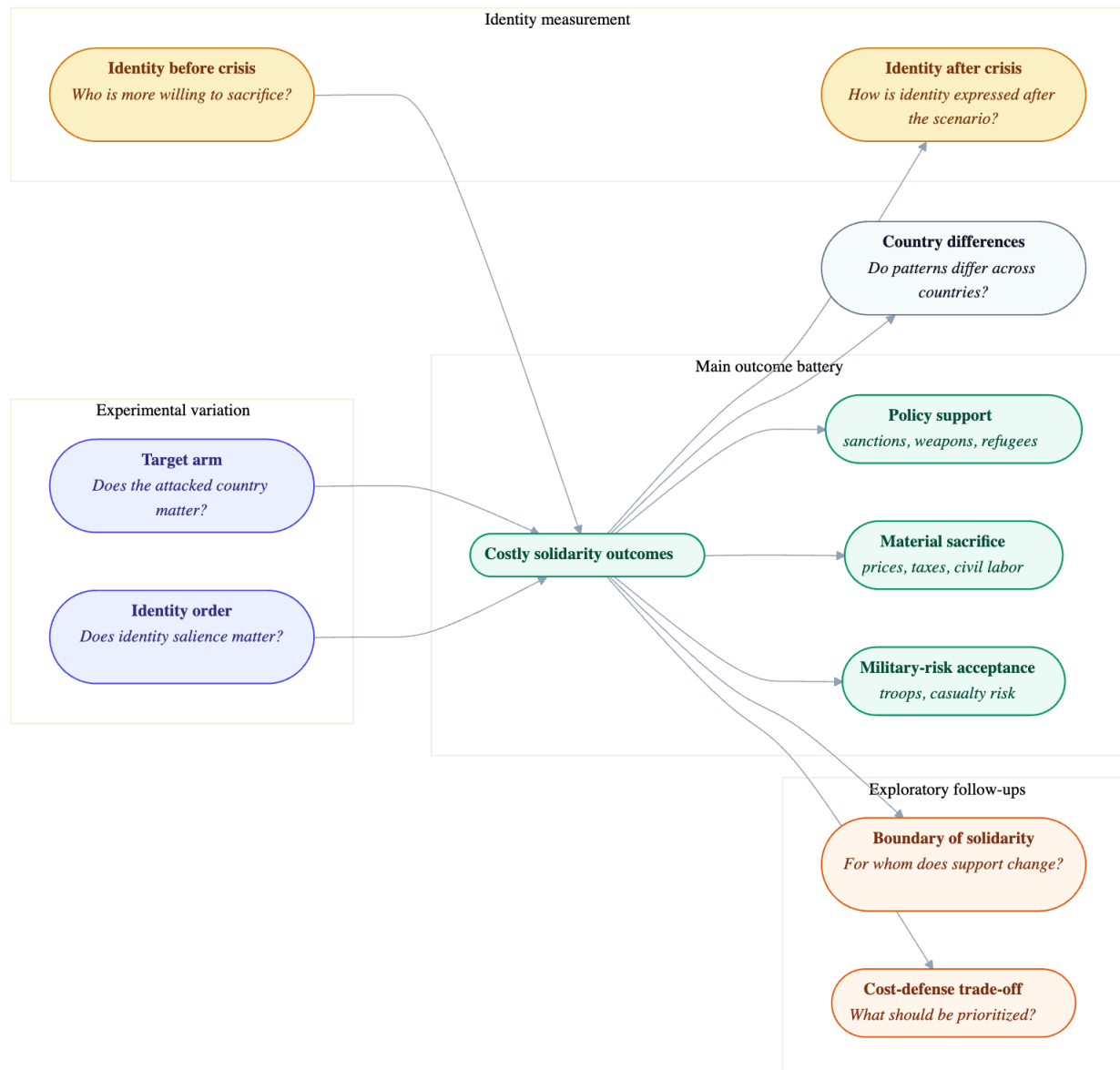


Figure 2: Analysis logic for identity order, target effects, and costly-solidarity outcomes.

References

Bechtel, Michael M., Jens Hainmueller, and Yotam Margalit. 2014. "Preferences for International Redistribution: The Divide over the Eurozone Bailouts." *American Journal of Political Science* 58 (4): 835–56. <https://doi.org/10.1111/ajps.12079>.

- Heermann, Max, Sebastian Koos, and Dirk Leuffen. 2023. "Who Deserves European Solidarity? How Recipient Characteristics Shaped Public Support for International Medical and Financial Aid during COVID-19." *British Journal of Political Science* 53 (2): 629–51. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S0007123422000357>.
- Kuhn, Theresa, and Aaron Kamm. 2019. "The National Boundaries of Solidarity: A Survey Experiment on Solidarity with Unemployed People in the European Union." *European Political Science Review* 11 (2): 179–95. <https://doi.org/10.1017/S1755773919000067>.
- Moise, Alexandru D., and Chendi Wang. 2025. "Appeasement or Solidarity? Uncovering the Drivers of European Public Opinion on the Eu's Foreign Policy." *European Union Politics* 26 (2): 418–41. <https://doi.org/10.1177/14651165251320837>.
- Oana, Ioana-Elena, Alexandru D. Moise, and Zbigniew Truchlewski. 2025. "Demand-Side Constraints on European Solidarity for Energy Sanctions: Experimental Evidence from Seven EU Countries." *European Union Politics* 26 (2): 344–68. <https://doi.org/10.1177/14651165251318955>.
- Tomz, Michael, and Jessica L. P. Weeks. 2021. "Military Alliances and Public Support for War." *International Studies Quarterly* 65 (3): 811–24. <https://doi.org/10.1093/isq/sqab015>.
- Tomz, Michael, Jessica L. P. Weeks, and Kirk Bansak. 2023. "How Membership in the North Atlantic Treaty Organization Transforms Public Support for War." *PNAS Nexus* 2 (7): pgad206. <https://doi.org/10.1093/pnasnexus/pgad206>.
- Verhaegen, Soetkin. 2018. "What to Expect from European Identity? Explaining Support for Solidarity in Times of Crisis." *Comparative European Politics* 16 (5): 871–904. <https://doi.org/10.1057/s41295-017-0106-x>.